Outside the Magistrate's Shadow: Media Beyond Local Authority and Cadre Promotion in China*

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Abstract

How can authoritarian regimes discipline local bureaucrats without the machinery of democratic accountability? Linking 1,528 fatal coal-mine accidents in 311 Chinese prefectures (2003–2012) to 11,190 news articles and the career outcomes of 967 prefecture party secretaries, I document a striking asymmetry: career penalties arise when accidents are covered by media based outside the incumbent's own province, while local coverage has no detectable negative effect. The penalty concentrates on the advancement margin—reducing retirement and promotion rather than triggering formal removal—consistent with a cadre tournament in which visibility constrains upward mobility. A news-congestion instrument provides first-stage evidence for the mechanism: it shifts non-local coverage significantly more than local coverage, exactly the asymmetry the mechanism predicts. These findings identify which information channels enter the promotion technology of a decentralized authoritarian hierarchy: not aggregate media scrutiny, but specifically those channels structurally independent of the leaders they scrutinize. The contribution is about the institutional design of monitoring in centralized administrative systems, not about the welfare consequences of media exposure.

Keywords: Cadre Promotion; Political Selection; Media Monitoring; M-form Hierarchy; Institutional Design; Jurisdictional Authority; Coal Mine Accidents.

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1 Introduction

Authoritarian leaders confront a persistent information problem. They need to know which of their local officials are performing, which are shirking, and which are concealing failures that could destabilize the regime. The democratic machinery that typically extracts such information—competitive elections, unfettered journalism, and organized opposition—is unavailable to them (Egorov, Guriev and Sonin 2009, Guriev and Treisman 2020). One prominent response, theorized most directly by Egorov, Guriev and Sonin (2009), is that rulers tolerate critical media in order to extract locally held information about subordinate performance; media freedom in this account is a complement to, not a substitute for, hierarchical monitoring. China's media system during the 2000s fits this general type: negative coverage of local governance is permitted within limits, and its contents feed into the personnel decisions that shape the state hierarchy (Chen and Xu 2017*a*, Lorentzen 2014, Repnikova 2017, Stockmann 2013). Yet the Egorov, Guriev and Sonin framework treats "media" as an aggregate: it predicts that more permissive media regimes will do more monitoring, but does not distinguish among types of coverage within a given regime. This paper argues that the distinction matters, and that recognizing it revises how we should understand media as an authoritarian accountability technology.

How does this arrangement actually function at the level of individual officials? The existing literature has documented associations between local governance failures and cadre careers in China (Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim 2015, Shih, Adolph and Liu 2012, Wang, Yao and Zhang 2022), as well as the broader information logic behind authoritarian media policy (Guriev and Treisman 2020, Wallace 2022). Two operational questions remain underexplored. First, once a failure has occurred, what is the object of central discipline—the objective severity of the event, or its public visibility through media coverage? Second, does all media coverage carry equal weight, or does the geography of reporting matter? The answers bear directly on what media freedom is "for" in a non-democratic setting, and on whether the accountability technology in question is robust or narrowly conditional.

Why would the geography of media coverage matter at all? The answer lies in the institutional architecture of the Chinese state. In the M-form hierarchy analyzed by Qian and Xu (1993) and formalized as *regionally decentralized authoritarianism* by Xu (2011), administrative authority is distributed along parallel territorial units as well as along a central-to-local chain of command. Each prefecture's propaganda apparatus is embedded in its own prefecture's party committee; peer prefectures exercise no formal authority over each other's media; and central-level outlets answer to the Central Publicity Department rather than to any provincial or prefecture leader. What unites all of these "outside" outlets—whether they sit at a higher administrative level or in a parallel branch of the hierarchy—is that none of them lies within the incumbent's own chain of command. Media geography therefore serves as an observable proxy for jurisdictional geography, and the specific accountability mechanism identified in this paper is a product of this particular institutional configuration rather than a universal feature of media under autocracy—a scope condition I return to in the discussion.

I address these questions using a panel of 311 Chinese prefectures over 2003–2012, a decade characterized by comparatively permissive media reporting on local governance (Stern and O'Brien 2012, Stockmann 2013). I link 1,528 serious coal-mine accidents recorded by

the State Administration of Work Safety to 11,190 news articles scraped from WiseNews, an archive spanning central, provincial, and commercial outlets. Career outcomes for the 967 prefecture party secretaries in the sample are coded using an ordinal measure of turnover (demoted, retired, lateral, promoted). All specifications absorb prefecture and year fixed effects and cluster standard errors at the prefecture.

The data yield two main findings. The first is a striking asymmetry in *where* coverage matters. In horse-race specifications that partition news reports by whether they originate inside or outside the accident's own province, *non-local* coverage carries a negative relationship with the incumbent's career outcomes (coefficient -0.05, $p < 0.01$); *local* coverage shows no detectable negative effect and, if anything, carries the opposite sign. The two news variables are only moderately correlated ($r = 0.40$ within the accident subsample), and their variance inflation factors in the horse race are below two—so the asymmetry is not an artifact of multicollinearity but a substantive feature of the data. The second finding concerns *where* the penalty lands. Non-local coverage does not increase the probability of outright termination, nor does it push leaders into lateral reassignment; it specifically reduces the probability that they advance out of office through retirement or promotion. The effect concentrates on the *advancement margin* rather than the removal margin—a pattern more consistent with a cadre tournament in which visibility constrains upward mobility than with a disciplinary apparatus that responds to exposure with formal sanctions. A descriptive mediation decomposition is consistent with media coverage as the operative channel between fatalities and turnover, but the decomposition is sensitive to small amounts of unobserved confounding of the mediator–outcome relationship; I therefore treat it as suggestive attribution rather than a formally identified mediation effect.

Rather than resting on a single instrument, I assemble multiple mechanism-consistent diagnostics. The strongest comes from a news-congestion shock: larger concurrent accidents elsewhere in China plausibly exogenously compress scarce national-media attention. The shock moves non-local coverage ($F = 13.9$) but leaves local coverage unmoved ($F < 1$), and the difference between the two first-stage coefficients is itself significant at better than 0.1% in a stacked specification with outcome-interacted fixed effects. This differential first-stage is itself a test of the proposed mechanism: national outlets face a finite-attention constraint; outlets embedded in local political economy do not. Supporting diagnostics—an appointment-selection falsification, a regression discontinuity at the legal "serious accident" threshold, and a news-generation model showing that political connections do not predict coverage—each address a distinct threat to inference (Section 4.4). I therefore do not advance a tight causal point estimate. I advance a descriptive pattern whose directional implications are triangulated by multiple mechanism-consistent tests.

Taken together, these results identify which information channels enter the promotion technology of a decentralized authoritarian hierarchy. Accountability in the Chinese cadre system traveled through information channels that sat outside local political control: local incumbents could shape in-province reporting, but had limited leverage over national and out-of-province outlets, and it was the latter whose coverage translated into career consequences. The economic contribution is to the institutional design of monitoring in centralized systems, not to the welfare consequences of media exposure—which, on the evidence presented below, the mechanism does not straightforwardly deliver. The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 situates the coal-mine regulatory and media-system context.

Section 3 introduces the data and variables. Section 4 presents the main results, identification diagnostics, and robustness checks. Section 5 discusses interpretation and limitations, and Section 6 concludes.

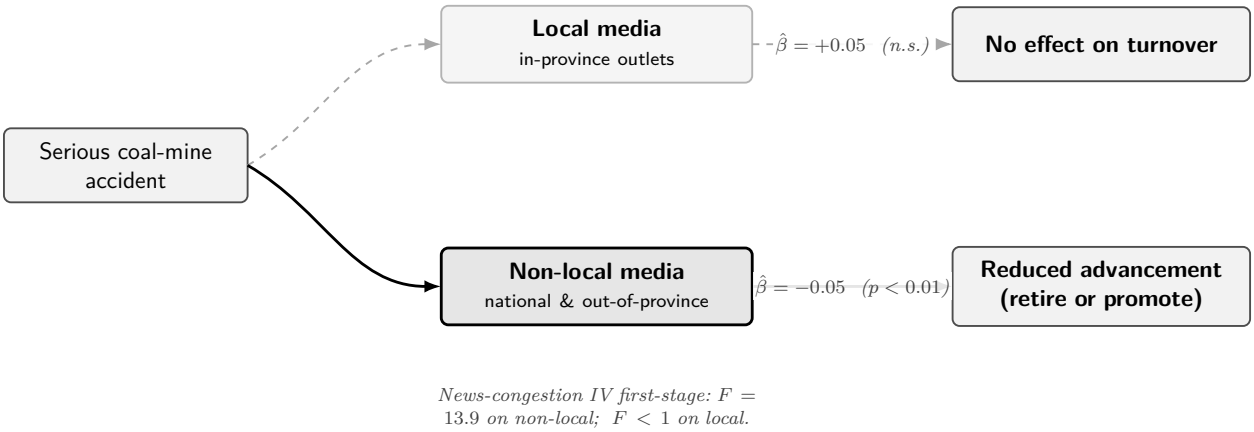


Figure 1: The asymmetric accountability channel.

Notes: The figure summarizes the paper's central mechanism. A serious coal-mine accident generates two coverage streams: reporting by outlets inside the accident's province ("local media") and reporting by outlets headquartered elsewhere ("non-local media"). Only the non-local stream carries a measurable career consequence. Coefficients on the arrows are from Column (5) of Table 2; the F-statistics are the differential first-stages of the news-congestion instrument (Section 4.4), showing that a shock crowding out non-local attention moves non-local coverage strongly but leaves local coverage unmoved.

2 Institutional Background

2.1 Power Decentralization in China

The post-Mao reform program responded to the poor performance of the pre-1970s command economy. A central plank of the 1990s reforms was the downward delegation of fiscal and administrative authority to subnational governments, intended to enable more flexible local governance and to foster regional competition. The reform succeeded in both dimensions but, as a by-product, sharply widened the information asymmetry between the center and its local agents.

As illustrated in Figure 2, China's administrative hierarchy follows a strict top-down delegation pattern: the central government appoints and supervises provincial leaders, who in turn appoint and supervise prefecture-level officials; each layer is formally responsible for decisions made at the layer immediately below it. Within this structure, regional governments have been assigned substantial authority over local issues: provincial governments appoint prefecture leaders, approve regional development plans, and collect and redistribute regional tax revenue. The power delegation makes competition for economic growth possible among incentivized local officials who seek promotion, and researchers believe these incentives have contributed to China's rapid economic growth over the past thirty years (Lin and Liu 2000).

Decentralization of power, however, comes with a cost to the central government. More discretion to make decisions comes with more opportunities of rent seeking for local govern-

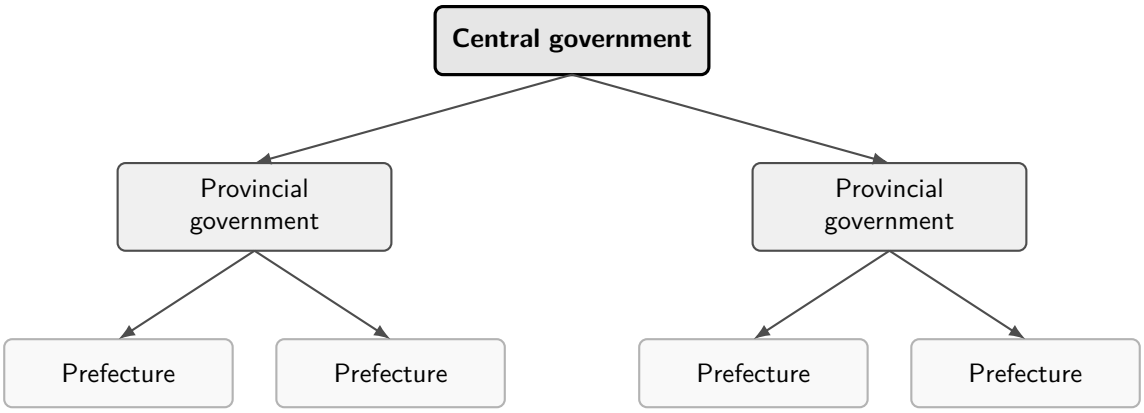


Figure 2: Pyramid hierarchical structure of the Chinese government.

Notes: The figure depicts the three tiers of the post-reform Chinese administrative hierarchy relevant to the paper. The central government appoints and supervises provincial leaders; provincial leaders in turn appoint and supervise prefecture-level party secretaries. Personnel decisions for prefecture secretaries are made one tier up—at the provincial level—so in-province outlets share the same supervisor as the incumbent they cover, while out-of-province outlets do not. This supervisory geometry is what the paper's local/non-local coverage decomposition exploits.

ments (Mattingly 2016). Driven by the corruption incentive, local officials tend to further disguise private information from central authority. A corrupted local government will erode the state capacity due to its low governance capability. Local power abuse, as a sign of autocrats' incapability to hold subordinates accountable, will also blemish central authority's image. Both the weakened administration capacity and the tarnished autocrat's image due to local power abuse threaten the rule of central government. Before taking any actions to neutralize those threats, autocrats need to grasp more local information.

2.2 Newspaper in China

China's newspapers are tightly controlled by the government, but in a more decentralized way. As one of the local affairs, the task to control and monitor regional media has been delegated to local governments (Sun 2012, Wang and Sparks 2019, Zhao 1998). For example, newspapers in prefecture X only directly respond to X's Publicity Department rather than prefecture Y's. Also, prefecture X is likely to cover up a scandal on itself. However, scandals in prefecture Y usually do no damage to and sometimes even benefit (Chen and Hong 2021) the politicians of prefecture X. In that respect, local government in X has less incentive to silence its local media to cover up for Y. Considering that there are more than 300 city-level governments in China, any single one of them has little capability to silence all of the local newspapers in other cities.

Alongside this reduction in political obstacles, commercial incentives pushed newspapers toward reporting on local scandals. The 1990s marketization of the newspaper industry cut, and in many cases removed entirely, the subsidies that papers had received from government. Survival for most outlets—except a handful of core party organs—became dependent on advertising revenue, which itself depended on circulation (Huang 2015, Shirk 2011, Zhao 1998). A number of papers transformed into commercially successful enterprises: the *South-*

ern Metropolis Daily (Nanfang Dushi Bao), founded in 1997 as a small local outlet, reached daily circulation above 1.4 million by 2008 (Stockmann 2013). Within a decade, the Chinese newspaper market was among the largest in the world by aggregate circulation.

This commercialization also aligned local governments with their local press. An influential local newspaper is a low-cost, high-impact publicity instrument for the jurisdiction in which it is based, and local governments accordingly encouraged its development. So long as coverage did not damage the supervising jurisdiction's interests, profit-seeking reporting was tolerated—including reporting that damaged *other* localities. Government scandal is one of the most reliably saleable topics in the Chinese press (Distelhorst and Hou 2014, Qin, Strömberg and Wu 2018, Shirk 2011), and *Southern Metropolis Daily*'s reputation for exposing official misconduct in other provinces is widely credited as one driver of its commercial rise.

Regional and commercial interests have thus become intertwined in local media's news-generation process (Huang 2015). Local outlets have strong commercial incentives to attract readers and little reason not to attract them with scandals in other provinces, where reporting is politically costless at home. The resulting cross-jurisdictional exposure raises the cost of concealment and, by implication, the credibility of the internal information reaching the center.

2.3 Coal Mine Safety in China

Coal mine accidents are common scandals of local governments in the 2000s. China is the world's largest producer and consumer of coal. Fast industrialization in the 1990s resulted in a dramatic increase in coal consumption. Despite of the success of media marketization, decentralization led to the weakened enforcement of safety regulations, resulting in a number of high-profile coal mine accidents with mass casualties (Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim 2015). Figure 3 illustrates the geographic distribution of fatalities. Those accidents triggered sharp criticism both at home and abroad, posing threats to social stability and crises of legitimacy for the central government (Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim 2015, Nie, Jiang and Wang 2013).

Most coal mine accidents in China are caused by human factors: the violation of regulations or mismanagement (Chen et al. 2012). Governments' better enforcement of safety regulation can significantly reduce the coal mine casualties (Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim 2015). Facing huge domestic and foreign pressure, Chinese government ranked fatal coal mine accidents reduction on the top of its agenda in the 2000s. Since 2000, central government has issued a series of regulations (Nie, Jiang and Wang 2013) and tried to tie the promotion incentives of local officials to the safety record of the areas where they governed. According to the national regulations issued in 2001,[1] "When an extremely fatal accident occurs, local government officials are penalized based on the severity of the accident, either through demotion or dismissal or through criminal procedures if dereliction of duty is involved." To protect themselves from punishment, local officials have strong incentives to cover coal mine accidents up once it cause fatalities. However, the attempt to disguise bears high risk of exposure under media supervision. Even though local officials can capture the branches of

[1] "Provisions of the State Council on Investigation for Administrative Responsibility for Extraordinarily Serious Safety Accidents"

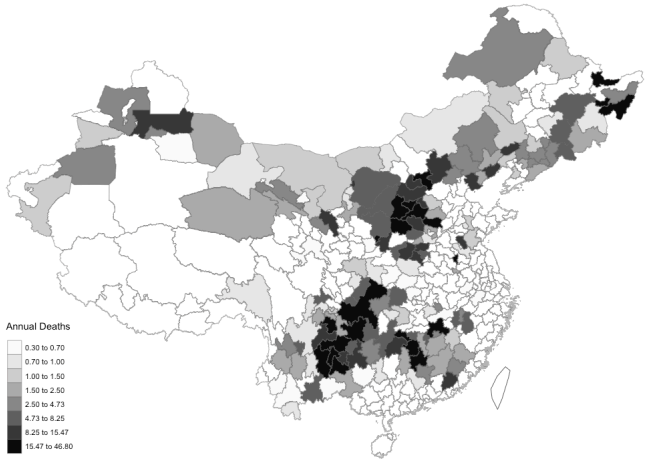


Figure 3: Geographic Distribution of Annual Deaths, 2003-2012

Notes: The map aggregates deaths in coal-mine accidents with at least three fatalities across 311 prefecture-level jurisdictions in mainland China over 2003–2012. Darker shading denotes higher cumulative fatalities; white indicates zero serious accidents. Of the 311 prefectures, 174 (55.9%) experienced at least one serious accident, spread across both developed (e.g. Guangdong) and underdeveloped (e.g. Inner Mongolia, Shanxi) provinces. The pattern tracks coal geology rather than regional development, supporting the treatment of accident incidence as plausibly exogenous to the incumbent's career trajectory.

internal monitoring system like SAWS, it is hard to silence all the newspapers in China. For instance, on 26 April 2011, a severe accident happened in Guifa Coal Mine, a mine in Didao District in Jixi of Heilongjiang province, caused 9 deaths. Mine owner and local officials tried to cover it up but failed five days after owing to the exposure by journalists of the Xinhua News Press. Based on the information provided by media, the local officials, including the deputy head of that district and the leaders of local SAWS, were removed or sentenced.

The media exposure of coal-mine scandals thus raises the cost of concealment and becomes a potential signal through which the center can evaluate local performance. Yet whether local officials actually face career consequences for scandals—and if so, which forms of coverage generate those consequences—remains an empirical question that the institutional description alone cannot answer.

2.4 Political Selection in China

Without competitive election, Chinese politicians are appointed directly by their supervisors. After the decentralization of power, regional governments' authority of appointing subordinates is consolidated. For example, provincial government can appoint leaders of prefectures by evaluation. The two major criteria of selecting candidates are economic performance (Chen, Li and Zhou 2005, Li and Zhou 2005, Maskin, Qian and Xu 2000, Xi, Yao and Zhang 2018) and loyalty to supervisors (Cai and Treisman 2006, Fisman et al. 2020, Jiang 2018, Shih, Adolph and Liu 2012). Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim (2015) finds that for a candidate to receive promotion, he or she has to meet both criteria. Delegated personnel

rights does not mean that the central authority can't intervene local political selection anymore. Instead, central government still holds the power to reward and punish local officials and is willing to exercise power based on its political agenda.

Political career is like a boat sailing against currents. The greatest reward to a politician in hierarchy is promotion. Central government can punish local officials in multiple ways, including but not limited to direct removal or demotion, redeploying to a new place with less power, or leaving them a stalled political career.

Punishing local officials who fail to enforce coal mine safety benefits the central authority. Firstly, ruling out incompetent subordinates can improve local bureaucracies' capability of fulfilling the assigned tasks. In the case of preventing fatal coal mine accidents, a more accountable local bureaucracy can better enforce central's safety regulations. Secondly, sanctioning officials can show central government's determination of reducing fatalities, creating an impression that central government's policy is good while local officials are bad at implementing it.

The four elements just reviewed—a decentralized administrative hierarchy, a partially marketized press whose political geography does not map onto the geography of the scandals it reports, a high-salience agenda item in coal-mine safety, and a personnel system in which career outcomes are set one tier above the scandal—together pose a single empirical question. If media coverage acts as a monitoring technology that a supervisor can actually use, the effective variation should not be aggregate coverage but the share of coverage that escapes the incumbent's jurisdictional reach. In-province outlets face alignment with the very official whose career is at stake; outlets headquartered elsewhere do not. Whether this geographic asymmetry in reporting actually translates into a measurable asymmetry in career outcomes—and, if so, through which margin of turnover—cannot be settled by institutional description and is the subject of the remainder of the paper.

3 Data and Variables

3.1 Data

Coal Mine Accidents. I collect all coal mine accident reports from 2003 to 2012 published by SAWS, a central government agency of China overseeing work safety. SAWS posts online new coal mine accidents countrywide from 2000 to 2015.[2] I only consider large accidents with at least three fatalities, because they have higher chances of inducing punishment and attracting media attention. The analysis window of 2003–2012 is dictated by two data constraints: SAWS reporting conventions stabilize at the three-death threshold only from 2006, with consistent pre-2006 records available back to 2003; and the WiseNews full-text archive that underlies the media measure provides reliable coverage over this window. The decade also coincides with a period of unchanged central leadership at the top of the administrative hierarchy, which keeps the rules governing personnel decisions and media

[2]The URL of the web page is http://media.chinasafety.gov.cn:8090/iSystem/shigumain.jsp, but it is no longer accessible after I collected all the data in 2015. Before January 2006, all coal mine accidents, with and without causalities, were posted. Henceforth, only large accidents with at least three fatalities will be updated on the website(Nie, Jiang and Wang 2013).

control constant across the sample.

In total, the accident dataset contains 1,528 cases from 27 of China's 31 provinces.[3] The records contain detailed information on accidents' dates and locations, which facilitate locating relevant news coverage. Of the 311 prefectures in China, 174 (55.9%) had coal mine accidents with at least three fatalities between 2003 and 2012. The geographic distribution of fatalities is illustrated in Figure 3. There is no clear distributive patterns of these 174 prefectures. They are from both developed provinces (like Guangdong) and underdeveloped provinces (like Inner Mongolia), distributing in both the north and the south of China. In fact, the location matches the geographic distribution of coal reservation better.

In the first two panels of Figure 4, I draw the monthly number of large coal mine accidents and their casualties. It shows that the coal mine accidents as serious socio-political issues — there were more than 100 victims in most of the months. However, both the monthly frequency and fatalities of large coal mine accidents gradually decreased during 2003 and 2012.

News Reports. Figure 5 illustrates how I extract accident metadata from SAWS records and construct search keywords. For each accident, I generate a keyword composed of the date, prefecture, and coal-mine name, and query it against the WiseNews full-text Chinese news database.[4] Using these keywords, I collect 11,190 newspaper articles covering the 1,528 accidents in the sample. The articles come from 239 different newspapers, including national party outlets such as *People's Daily* and regional commercial outlets such as *Southern Metropolis Daily*.

Besides those articles, I also obtain information of newspapers from the *Directory of Chinese Newspapers in China 2010 (Zhongguo Xinban Baozhi Minglu 2010)*[5]. Based on these information, I classify the newspapers into two: party line and commercial; national and local. These categories allow me to investigate the heterogeneous effects of media on political selection.

Fatalities and news-coverage intensity are correlated but separable: their sample correlation is 0.77, leaving substantial residual variation in visibility after conditioning on severity. Two accidents from 2004 illustrate the wedge. A ten-fatality accident at Beijing's *Daanshan Coal Mine* and a ten-fatality accident at Guizhou's *Liuhe Coal Mine* drew dramatically different press responses—ten times more articles on the former—despite identical death counts. The disparity tracks each prefecture's general prominence rather than accident severity. To absorb this kind of baseline attention differential, I control for the total number of articles mentioning prefecture i in year t.

Cadre Resumes. I construct a dataset of local cadre resumes by first obtaining the names of all prefecture party secretaries from each province's provincial yearbook (*Sheng Nianjian*). I also use Baidu Encyclopedia (*Baidu Baike*) to gather their personal information, such as age, gender, place of birth, education, and work history. In total, 967 cadres held

[3]Four mainland provinces or province-level municipalities are excluded because they had no coal mine accidents with at least three fatalities in 2003-2012: Zhejiang, Hainan, Shanghai, and Tianjin.

[4]Because some articles may reference only a subset of these fields (e.g., date and location but not the mine name), the news-coverage measure is conservative and the estimates reported below may understate the true effect of media visibility. WiseNews is a Hong Kong-based aggregator covering 1.4 billion Chinese-language news articles dating back to 1998; see http://wisenews.wisers.net.

[5]Published by the China Press and Publications Administration in 2011.

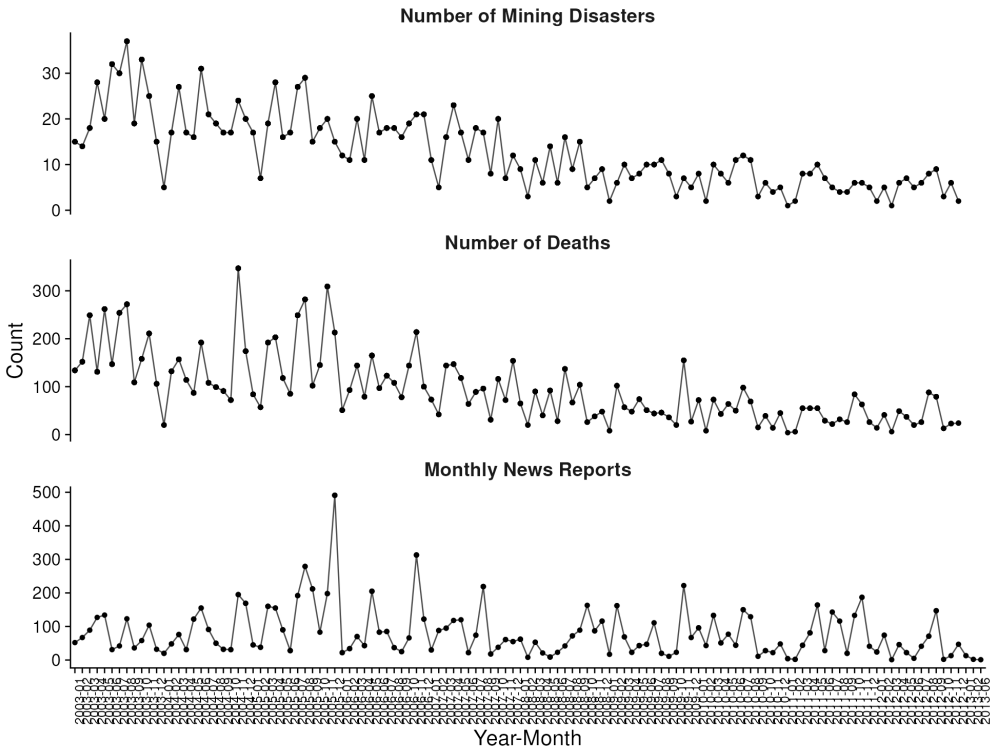


Figure 4: Monthly Coal Mine Accidents, Fatalities, and Media Coverage

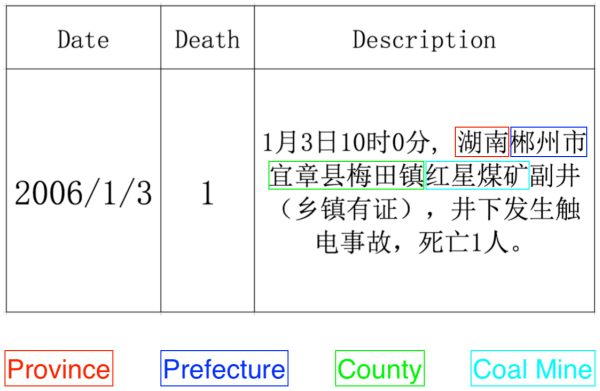
Notes: Monthly counts of the three inputs to the main analysis, 2003–2012. Panel 1: coal-mine accidents with at least three fatalities. Panel 2: corresponding death toll. Panel 3: newspaper articles reporting those accidents, dated by publication. Accident data are from SAWS; news data are from the WiseNews Full-Text Chinese Newspaper Database. Both accident frequency and fatalities decline over the sample, motivating year fixed effects. Media coverage does not simply track event frequency—the imperfect alignment between coverage and fatality peaks is the cross-accident variation the paper exploits to separate severity from visibility.

the position of prefecture party secretary from 2003 to 2012; among those, 916 (94.7%) had detailed biographies that could be located.

3.2 Variables

Political Turnover. My outcome variable is the political turnover of prefecture party secretaries. Each year, an incumbent party secretary faces five possible career trajectories: 1) being promoted to a higher rank (as defined by the position' s administration level and political influence), 2) being transferred laterally to positions of the same rank, 3) staying in the same office, 4) retiring due to age, and 5) being demoted due to misconduct.[6] Following Chen and Xu (2017*b*), Li and Zhou (2005), political turnover is coded as an ordinal

[6]In cases where there are two prefecture party secretaries serving in the same year - one outgoing and the other incoming - I follow Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim (2015), Li and Zhou (2005), Shih, Adolph and Liu (2012) and match the data of those whose terms ended before (or, alternatively, started from) the 1st of July of a given year. See Table A.1 for more detailed coding rules.



Date	Death	Description
2006/1/3	1	1月3日10时0分，湖南郴州市宜章县梅田镇红星煤矿副井（乡镇有证），井下发生触电事故，死亡1人。

Province Prefecture County Coal Mine

Figure 5: Example of an SAWS coal-mine accident record and the extracted search keywords.

Notes: A representative SAWS record (the 3 January 2006 accident at Hongxing Coal Mine in Chenzhou, Hunan) and the keyword used to locate matching media coverage. The extraction rule is constant across the dataset: date + prefecture name + coal-mine name, conjunctive search against WiseNews. For the example shown, the keyword is "2006 年 1 月 3 日 + 郴州 + 红星煤矿." The requirement of a structured match makes the coverage measure conservative: articles using only partial metadata are excluded, so estimated media effects in Table 2 should be read as lower bounds. Because the keyword is constructed from the SAWS record rather than from press text, the article count reflects press behavior, not recording artifacts.

variable, with promotion taking on the value of 3; lateral transfer and/or staying in office, 2; retirement, 1; and termination or demotion, 0. Three sample counts appear throughout the paper and refer to different units of observation: 1,528 is the count of coal-mine accidents with at least three fatalities; 967 is the count of distinct prefecture party secretaries holding office during the sample window; and 3,139 is the count of prefecture-year observations that constitute the main analysis panel (roughly 311 prefectures over ten years, net of missing covariates). Figure 6 shows the distribution of political turnover for the 3,139 prefecture-year observations. We see the proportion of promotions only accounts for 11%, while an overwhelming percentage (83.40%) is "no change" or lateral transfers. Moreover, the ratio of retirements and moving to the "rubber stamp" parliament together is 4.94%[7], and only 0.48% of the observations are terminations because of corruption charges or natural deaths.

Coal Mine Accidents. I use the number of deaths as the measure of the severity of coal mine accidents. By aggregating the fatalities in coal mine accidents to year interval, I can further link the causalities to local officials' turnover. I also apply a dummy variable denoting the existence and the number of large coal mine accidents in a year.

Media Coverage of Accidents. Besides the number of fatalities in coal mine accidents, another independent variable of interest is the media coverage. Similar to the number of deaths, I want to aggregate all the relevant news articles to year interval. But newspa-

[7]Although a move to a political body at provincial level like People's Congress or People's Political Consultative conference may seem like a promotion, it is in fact widely considered to be *de facto* retirement in Chinese political system, because the party secretary will loses substantive power and cease to be a candidate for further promotion.

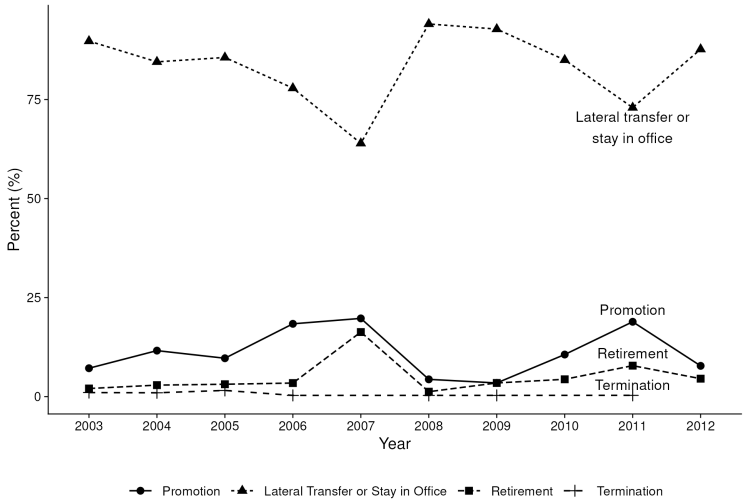


Figure 6: Political Turnover of Prefecture Party Secretaries, 2003-2012

Notes: Empirical distribution of the paper's dependent variable across 3,139 prefecture-year observations: promotions 11.18%, lateral transfers or staying 83.40%, retirements or moves into the provincial "rubber-stamp" parliament 4.94%, and formal terminations or demotions 0.48%. Because terminations are exceedingly rare, the main analysis decomposes the ordinal outcome (Table 3) and locates the effect on the advancement margin (retire-or-promote vs. terminate-or-stay)—substantively common and tightly linked to the tournament-style promotion system of Section 2.

pers might need considerable time to cover the accidents. To avoid under-weighting media coverage of accidents happened at the end of each year, I consider different time windows to define valid media coverage. More inclusively, I accept all the news articles published between the date of one accident and the last year the local official at work. Alternatively, I limit all articles to a fixed time window with 365 days after the accidents. To control for newspapers' attention on certain city, I generate an variable by counting the total number of news reports mentioning the name of prefecture i in year t.

Loyalty and Performance. Existing research emphasizes the importance of candidates' loyalty and performance on receiving promotion. To find the influence of coal mine accidents, we should condition on those two factors. I use multiple variables to measure a candidate's loyalty. First, if a prefecture leader is governing a city in his home province, he may enjoy some benefits by virtue of his local connections. Usually, a local cadre knows the local officialdom better or has a stronger social network in the provincial government (Shih, Adolph and Liu 2012, Zhang and Liu 2019). The acquaintance network may give candidate's advantages in the campaign. Thus, I generate a dummy variable indicating the candidate is native, and there are 602 (64.80%) secretaries working in the provinces of birth. Secondly, a candidate who shares factional ties with his supervisor is more likely to be promoted (Opper and Brehm 2007, Shih, Adolph and Liu 2012). I generate dummy variables indicating the workplace and birthplace ties to supervisors. Specifically, workplace dummy equals to one if a prefecture secretary used to work with his or her supervisor; while birthplace dummy equals to one if candidate and supervisor, the provincial party secretary, are from the same hometown.

In the context of economy competition, I follow (Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim 2015, Li

and Zhou 2005) and use the annual economic growth of a prefecture as the measure of an incumbent's performance. To be more specific, I control for the size and the development of a prefecture's economy, measured by GDP per capita (log), population (log), and GDP growth rate.

Personal Demographics. Besides political connection and economic performance, candidates' demographics also matter in the political selection. This study captures the demographic information of candidate' s age, seniority, and education. In Chinese political system, prefecture leader older than 55 will probably be forced to retire with mere promotion chances. Thus, their behaviors may differ from others'. The seniority of candidates matters in the way that the longer one stays in the same office, the more chances of promotion he holds. However, there is also evidence suggesting that promotion would be impossible if one spends too much time at the same position(Guo 2009). Therefore, I include both year in office, the squared term, and a dummy variable indicating a cadre' s second term in my estimations. On average, a prefecture party secretary spends 4.5 years in one position. Another factor influencing promotion is education (Shih, Adolph and Liu 2012). As illustrated in those cases, the majority of prefecture leaders (92.52%) have earned a bachelor degree or above.

In Table 1, I show the statistical summary of some variables I used in the empirical analysis.

Table 1: The Statistical Summary

Statistic	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Max
Political Turnover	3,139	2.053	0.421	0	3
Accident Dummy	3,139	0.220	0.415	0	1
Death (log)	3,139	0.501	1.044	0	5.193
Media Coverage (log)	3,139	0.296	0.884	0	5.908
Number of Accidents (log)	3,139	0.228	0.479	0	3.332
Total Coverage (log)	3,139	6.288	1.173	0	10.789
Age	3,112	51.675	3.813	27	70
Time in Office	3,139	2.790	1.687	1	11
Local Cadre	3,095	0.662	0.473	0	1
Local Provincial PS	3,139	0.104	0.306	0	1
Political Connection (Colleague)	3,085	0.274	0.446	0	1
Political Connection (Hometown)	3,095	0.121	0.327	0	1

Notes: Descriptive statistics for the main prefecture-year panel. Political Turnover is coded on a four-point scale from 0 (termination or demotion) to 3 (promotion); Accident Dummy is 1 if the prefecture experienced a coal-mine accident with ≥ 3 fatalities that year (22.0% of prefecture-years). Promotions are rare relative to lateral transfers, which motivates the advancement-margin decomposition in Table 3. Sample sizes vary across covariates because some leader biographies are incomplete; the fully controlled regressions use 2,911–2,989 of the 3,139 prefecture-year observations.

4 Empirical Results

4.1 Non-Local Coverage Drives the Career Penalty

The paper's central question is whether the career consequences of a local scandal depend on *where* the scandal is reported. To answer it, I estimate the linear probability model

$$\begin{aligned} Turnover_{ijt} = & \beta_1 Accident_{ijt} + \beta_2 Accident_{ijt} \times \log(Deaths_{ijt} + 1) + \\ & \beta_3 Accident_{ijt} \times \log(NewsNonLocal_{ijt} + 1) + \\ & \beta_4 Accident_{ijt} \times \log(NewsLocal_{ijt} + 1) + X_{ijt} + \phi_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{ijt}, \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where $Turnover_{ijt}$ is the ordinal turnover of prefecture i's incumbent secretary j in year t; $Accident_{ijt}$ flags the presence of any serious (≥ 3 deaths) coal-mine accident; $NewsNonLocal$ and $NewsLocal$ decompose coverage by whether the reporting outlet sits inside or outside the accident's province; X_{ijt} collects leader, economic, and media-attention controls; and ϕ_i and δ_t absorb prefecture and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the prefecture.

Because the horse race in Equation 1 relies on separating two coverage measures that are in principle correlated, the exercise is credible only if the two regressors carry genuinely distinct statistical content. Within the accident-year subsample that identifies the interaction terms, the Pearson correlation between $\log(NewsNonLocal + 1)$ and $\log(NewsLocal + 1)$ is 0.40; over the full prefecture-year panel it is 0.52. Variance-inflation factors in the full specification are 1.98 for the non-local interaction and 1.88 for the local interaction—comfortably below the conventional threshold of five and inconsistent with the kind of multicollinearity that would invalidate separate interpretation of the two coefficients.

A non-parametric counterpart to this horse race—LOWESS fits of turnover against fatalities, non-local-news residuals, and local-news residuals—is reported in Appendix Figure A.1 and carries the same directional pattern without imposing a functional form.

Table 2 reports the benchmark results. Column (1) replicates the pooled-news specification of prior work: conditioning on total coverage, fatalities exert no detectable direct effect on turnover, while the coefficient on media coverage is negative and significant. The substantive content of that result, however, is revealed only when coverage is decomposed by geography. Non-local coverage, estimated alone in Column (3) and in the horse race of Column (5), enters with a coefficient of roughly -0.05 and a t-statistic above 3; local coverage, in contrast, is estimated imprecisely with the opposite sign. The asymmetry survives the addition of the leader's political connections and a dummy for the presence of central-media coverage in Column (6). Notably, the central-media dummy itself is statistically zero, which suggests that what operates is not central coverage as such but the broader category of reporting that originates outside the prefecture's own political jurisdiction.

Table 2: Main Result: Non-Local vs Local Media Coverage and Leader Turnover

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Accident	−0.014	−0.045	−0.052	−0.012	−0.052	−0.060
	(0.050)	(0.052)	(0.052)	(0.052)	(0.053)	(0.053)
Accident × Log(Death)	−0.023	0.016	0.019	−0.026	0.017	0.021
	(0.020)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.023)	(0.026)	(0.027)
Accident × Log(Total News)		−0.040**				
		(0.017)				
Accident × Log(Non-Local News)			−0.043**		−0.052***	−0.048**
			(0.017)		(0.017)	(0.023)
Accident × Log(Local News)				0.013	0.047	0.054*
				(0.033)	(0.032)	(0.032)
Central Media Present						−0.011
						(0.061)
Local Cadre						−0.035
						(0.028)
Local Provincial PS						−0.076
						(0.049)
Political Connection (Colleague)						−0.004
						(0.030)
Political Connection (Hometown)						0.005
						(0.050)
R^2	0.154	0.156	0.157	0.154	0.157	0.163
Adj. R^2	0.043	0.045	0.045	0.043	0.046	0.048
Num. obs.	2989	2989	2989	2989	2989	2911
N Clusters	328	328	328	328	328	327

Notes: Flagship specification. Dependent variable is the ordinal turnover outcome for the incumbent prefecture party secretary, coded from 0 (termination or demotion) to 3 (promotion). Columns (1)–(2) use pooled coverage; Columns (3)–(6) decompose coverage into non-local and local components. The key result is the horse race in Columns (5)–(6): Accident × Log(Non-Local News) is negative and significant, while Accident × Log(Local News) is small, imprecise, and often positive. Column (6) shows the asymmetry survives political-connection controls and a central-media dummy (itself null). Robust standard errors clustered at prefecture. All regressions include prefecture and year fixed effects and control for age, age^2, tenure, tenure^2, second-term status, education, GDP growth, log GDP per capita, and log population. $^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$.

4.2 The Advancement Margin

The four-level turnover variable aggregates outcomes that differ in kind—termination, retirement, lateral reassignment, and promotion. Decomposing the outcome into three binary recodings makes visible which margin carries the effect. Table 3 reports this decomposition.

Table 3: Promotion Margin: Non-Local Media Specifically Reduces Upward Mobility

	Ordinal 0-3	Non-termination	Graceful Exit	Promotion
Accident	−0.050	−0.002	−0.057*	0.010
	(0.053)	(0.004)	(0.030)	(0.038)
Accident × Log(Death)	0.017	0.004**	0.016	−0.003
	(0.026)	(0.002)	(0.015)	(0.018)
Accident × Log(Non-Local News)	−0.048**	−0.004	−0.030**	−0.015
	(0.022)	(0.004)	(0.014)	(0.013)
Accident × Log(Local News)	0.047	0.004	0.017	0.026
	(0.032)	(0.006)	(0.017)	(0.023)
Central Media Present	−0.012	0.003	0.022	−0.036
	(0.059)	(0.007)	(0.037)	(0.037)
R^2	0.157	0.138	0.217	0.231
Num. obs.	2989	2989	2989	2989
RMSE	0.410	0.065	0.212	0.295
N Clusters	328	328	328	328

Notes: The table locates which career margin the non-local-media penalty operates on. Same panel and controls as Table 2, re-estimated under four outcome definitions: the ordinal four-level scale; a non-termination dummy; a "graceful exit" dummy (retire-or-promote); and a pure-promotion dummy. Non-local coverage enters negatively and significantly on the baseline ordinal model and on Graceful Exit; it is null on Non-termination and on pure Promotion. Local coverage is null throughout. Robust standard errors clustered at prefecture; prefecture and year fixed effects and baseline controls included. $^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$.

The pattern is consistent across estimators. Non-local coverage has no relationship with the probability of outright termination (Column 2): leaders whose accidents draw outside scrutiny are no more likely to be formally removed. Nor does the effect run through the "promoted only" margin (Column 4), which is imprecise. The significant effect concentrates on the *advancement* coding of Column (3), which combines retirement and promotion against the twin possibilities of termination and lateral reassignment. Non-local coverage reduces the probability that an incumbent exits office through either form of forward motion, effectively stranding leaders in their current posts. This pattern is more consistent with a cadre-tournament mechanism—in which visibility constrains discretionary advancement—than with a disciplinary apparatus that responds to exposure with formal removal.

4.3 Mediation as Descriptive Attribution

A natural follow-up question is whether the conditional relationship between fatalities and turnover runs through media coverage itself or through other channels such as internal reporting and central inspection that need not route through the press. A parametric mediation decomposition (Imai, Keele and Tingley 2010) provides a descriptive answer under sequential-ignorability assumptions that are, in this setting, strong. Taking $\log(Deaths_{ijt}+1)$ as the treatment, $\log(News_{ijt}+1)$ as the mediator, and $Turnover_{ijt}$ as the outcome, the total effect of fatalities is estimated at -0.050 (95% confidence interval $[-0.097, -0.009]$,

$p = 0.020$), the average causal mediation effect through media is -0.026 ($[-0.052, -0.001]$, $p = 0.048$), and the direct effect net of the mediator is statistically indistinguishable from zero. Table 4 summarizes the decomposition.

Table 4: Mediation Decomposition: Death → News → Turnover

Effect	Estimate	95% CI	p-value	Note
Total effect (death → turnover)	-0.0501	$[-0.0969, -0.0089]$	0.020	Sig.
ACME indirect (via news)	-0.0262	$[-0.0521, -0.0007]$	0.048	Sig.
ADE direct (news controlled)	-0.0238	$[-0.0774, +0.0215]$	0.356	n.s.
Proportion mediated	52.3%	–	0.060	Marginal

Notes: Descriptive mediation decomposition: treatment is log fatalities, mediator is log total news coverage, outcome is the four-level turnover variable. The indirect effect through news is negative and marginally significant; the direct effect is null. The decomposition is, however, fragile: the ACME crosses zero at $\rho \approx 0$, so even small unobserved mediator–outcome confounding would eliminate it. I therefore treat this as suggestive attribution only, and the paper's core claim continues to rest on the geographic asymmetry in Table 2. Method follows Imai, Keele and Tingley (2010), quasi-Bayesian with 500 simulations. Controls: age, tenure, education, second term, GDP, population, political connections. $N = 2{,}911$.

The decomposition is consistent with the hypothesis that media coverage is the operative channel, but it is not a causal identification of that channel. An Imai-Yamamoto sensitivity analysis indicates that the average causal mediation effect crosses zero at a correlation between mediator and outcome errors of approximately zero, meaning that even a small amount of unobserved confounding of the media-turnover relationship would erase the estimated contribution of media. For this reason I do not attach a specific share of the total effect to the media channel and treat this decomposition as suggestive attribution rather than as independent identification. The weight of the evidence for the media mechanism continues to rest on the geographic asymmetry documented in Tables 2 and 3, which does not require sequential ignorability to interpret.

4.4 Identification Diagnostics

Three diagnostics probe what the OLS association can and cannot sustain.

Endogenous appointment. One natural alternative explanation is that accident-prone prefectures are systematically assigned better-connected cadres, who are then insulated from coverage. Regressing the characteristics of newly appointed leaders on prior-year accident history yields seventeen of eighteen coefficients that cannot be distinguished from zero; the sole marginal exception fails a Bonferroni correction for multiple testing. Appendix Table A.5 reports the results. The data, in other words, give no evidence of the reverse-selection mechanism that would generate the main association as a statistical artifact.

News-congestion instrument. Within a leader's tenure, media coverage is itself endogenous to governance quality: well-connected officials may be able to shape the volume and tone of reporting. I therefore instrument coverage with a plausibly exogenous shock

to competing national-media supply—the presence, within a ±7-day window, of a larger concurrent accident elsewhere in China. The intuition is that national coverage capacity is finite, and a simultaneous larger event elsewhere should mechanically crowd it out; local reporting, which is not bound by such a capacity constraint, should be unaffected. The data support exactly this pattern. The congestion shock reduces non-local coverage with a first-stage F-statistic of 13.9 and a coefficient of -0.45; the first-stage on local coverage is essentially flat, with $F < 1$ and a coefficient of $+0.04$. To test whether the gap between these two first-stage coefficients is itself statistically distinguishable from zero I estimate the pair jointly as a seemingly-unrelated regression with prefecture-by-outcome and year-by-outcome fixed effects and a prefecture-clustered covariance matrix. The joint test rejects equality decisively: the difference $\hat{\pi}_{\text{nonlocal}} - \hat{\pi}_{\text{local}}$ is -0.488 with a cluster-robust standard error of 0.119 ($t = -4.10$, $p < 0.0001$). This formally documented *differential relevance*—a shock that moves outside coverage but leaves inside coverage unmoved—is itself evidence for the mechanism, independent of what one does with the second stage. The resulting 2SLS on non-local coverage yields a point estimate ($\hat{\beta}^{\text{2SLS}} = -0.13$) that is directionally consistent with the OLS but, under Anderson-Rubin weak-IV-robust inference, a 95% confidence interval of $[-0.34, +0.07]$ that cannot exclude zero. I therefore do not rely on the 2SLS for a causal magnitude; the diagnostic value lies in the asymmetric first-stage.

Regression discontinuity at severity thresholds. Chinese regulation classifies accidents by fatality count, with ten or more fatalities triggering mandatory provincial-level investigation and thirty or more invoking the State Council. A sharp RD at the ten-death threshold yields a clean discontinuity in coverage ($+0.94$, $p = 0.03$) but a noisy, wrong-signed reduced form in the turnover dimension. McCrary density tests reject no-manipulation at every threshold, likely reflecting the post-2006 reporting convention that itself samples accidents discontinuously at three deaths. I therefore treat the RD's first-stage as mechanism-consistent supporting evidence and do not extract a causal estimate from it.

4.5 News Generation

A distinct concern, independent of the two-stage design, is whether the cross-accident variation in coverage used as a regressor reflects political capture rather than genuine visibility. If well-connected officials systematically suppress reporting on accidents under their jurisdiction, then $NewsNonLocal$ and $NewsLocal$ would not be measuring media attention as such but would be proxying for political influence itself; the asymmetric correlation with turnover documented in Section 4.1 could then be an artifact of how the coverage regressor is generated rather than of the monitoring mechanism the paper proposes. This concern motivates modeling coverage as an outcome of its own determinants.

Table 5 models the article count per accident as a function of commercial features and of the connections of the prefecture party secretary governing at the time of the accident. Commercial features include the accident's fatality count, indicators of how much coverage competing accidents received in the preceding week, and signals of whether early reporting was by influential national outlets. Political-connection controls include whether the leader was natively born in the province, whether the leader shares prior workplace ties with the incumbent provincial party secretary, and whether the two share home-province

ties. Columns (1)-(3) use the full article count as the dependent variable; Columns (4)-(6) restrict to in-province articles, which are the coverage closest to the leader's own administrative authority and therefore the most likely site of suppression if it were happening.

Table 5: Where Do the News Reports Come From?

	News	News	News	News	News	News (same province)	News (other province)
Deaths (log)	1.499***	1.505***	1.077***	1.068***	1.075***	0.308***	1.054***
	(0.053)	(0.053)	(0.058)	(0.058)	(0.064)	(0.056)	(0.063)
Recent Larger Accidents Elsewhere		0.066	0.158**	0.160**	0.150*	0.032	0.162**
		(0.073)	(0.061)	(0.063)	(0.076)	(0.052)	(0.067)
First Day Reports from Beijing Media			1.181***	1.176***	1.218***	0.104**	1.212***
			(0.074)	(0.074)	(0.075)	(0.041)	(0.072)
First Day Reports from Abroad Media				0.788***	0.785***	0.065	0.793***
				(0.134)	(0.154)	(0.096)	(0.159)
Political Connection (Workplace)					0.081	0.005	0.072
					(0.090)	(0.066)	(0.092)
Political Connection (Hometown)					−0.206*	0.038	−0.229**
					(0.108)	(0.110)	(0.105)
Local Cadre					0.109	0.082	0.095
					(0.089)	(0.068)	(0.081)
CYL Experience					0.062	0.018	0.045
					(0.086)	(0.048)	(0.088)
Local Provincial PS					0.292***	0.086	0.216*
					(0.110)	(0.105)	(0.113)
R^2	0.659	0.659	0.783	0.789	0.800	0.493	0.803
Adj. R^2	0.610	0.610	0.752	0.758	0.762	0.397	0.766
Num. obs.	1528	1528	1528	1528	1224	1224	1224
N Clusters	172	172	172	172	167	167	167

Notes: Accident-level model of coverage generation. Dependent variable is the article count per accident: total (Cols. 1–5), in-province only (Col. 6), and out-of-province only (Col. 7). Commercial news values (fatality count, recent larger accidents elsewhere, first-day reporting by Beijing or foreign outlets) strongly predict article volume. Political-connection variables are mostly null, including for in-province coverage where suppression would be most costly to a connected leader. The observed asymmetry in Table 2 therefore does not appear to be driven by political capture of the press. Standard errors clustered at prefecture. $^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$.

Across both outcome variables, commercial features dominate. The accident's fatality count is a strongly significant predictor in every specification: larger events attract more articles, as one would expect of a functioning commercial press. Storyline momentum—whether recent accidents in the news cycle drew substantial coverage—and early reporting by national outlets are also significant, consistent with a literature in media economics in which editorial decisions respond to the supply of competing stories and to early signals of newsworthiness. Political-connection variables, in contrast, are uniformly indistinguishable from zero. Whether the leader was born in the province, whether the leader previously worked with the provincial secretary, and whether the two share hometown ties—none enters with a coefficient that would be statistically distinguishable from zero at any conventional level, and point estimates do not exhibit the consistent negative sign that the suppression hypothesis would predict.

This null on political connections is, for the paper's argument, the essential finding of the news-generation exercise. It implies that the variation in coverage the main specification is using does not simply reflect which officials have enough pull to quiet the press. The

implication holds whether one examines total coverage, in which suppression would be most costly to a connected leader, or in-province coverage, where the leader's authority over local outlets is most direct. If the observed gap between non-local and local coverage were generated by political capture, one would expect political-connection controls to sharply reduce in-province reporting; the data do not show this. The career penalty identified in Section 4.1 therefore appears to attach to genuine visibility, not to a hidden measure of political weakness.

4.6 Heterogeneity

Disaggregating non-local coverage further clarifies the mechanism. Table 6 distinguishes among national newspapers, foreign outlets, and commercial newspapers headquartered outside the accident's province. The career penalty concentrates in the first and third categories—central and non-province commercial outlets—which share the structural feature that local incumbents have no direct administrative authority over them. Coverage by foreign media and by in-province outlets, neither of which carries the same mix of operational independence and domestic political weight, shows no detectable relationship with turnover.

Two characteristics of an outlet therefore appear to jointly determine whether its coverage binds: reach into audiences that the relevant supervisor actually reads, and insulation from the incumbent leader's administrative authority. Outlets that satisfy only one condition—foreign press, which is insulated but largely outside the domestic political audience; in-province commercial press, which reaches the right readers but sits under the wrong authority—do not produce measurable career consequences. This joint structure is what makes the paper's mechanism narrower than a generic "media exposure" story and is what delivers the prediction that aggregate coverage should look noisier than its geographic decomposition.

4.7 Robustness

The main result is stable under several further checks, reported in the Appendix. An ordered-logistic estimation of Equation 1—which better respects the ordinal nature of turnover—yields coefficients on non-local coverage between -0.26 and -0.32, significant at the one-percent level across specifications (Appendix Table A.2). Re-defining the news variable over a 365-day backward-looking window (Appendix Table A.3) or over the calendar year (Appendix Table A.4) preserves both the sign and the order of magnitude of the coefficient. Finally, regressions of next-year accident rates on the preceding year's coverage intensity return null results, inconsistent with both a simple learning interpretation and a simple window-dressing rebound, and reinforcing the interpretation that the mechanism identified here operates through cadre sorting rather than through short-run behavioral feedback.

Table 6: The Benchmark Results (Death ≥ 3), Different News Press

	Local Media	Non-Local Media	National Media	Foreign Media	Others
Accident	-0.064	-0.095^{*}	-0.098^{*}	-0.078	-0.092^{*}
	(0.052)	(0.053)	(0.054)	(0.052)	(0.053)
Accident x Death	-0.055^{**}	-0.008	-0.011	-0.038	-0.018
	(0.027)	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.028)	(0.029)
Accident x Local Media Coverage	0.021	0.052^{*}	0.052^{*}	0.034	0.044
	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.032)	(0.030)
Accident x Other Media Coverage		-0.048^{***}	-0.062^{***}	-0.078^{*}	-0.044^{***}
		(0.016)	(0.022)	(0.041)	(0.017)
Accident x Number of Accidents (log)	0.125^{*}	0.102	0.107^{*}	0.112^{*}	0.102
	(0.064)	(0.063)	(0.064)	(0.065)	(0.063)
R^2	0.162	0.164	0.164	0.163	0.163
Adj. R^2	0.046	0.049	0.049	0.047	0.048
Num. obs.	2911	2911	2911	2911	2911
N Clusters	327	327	327	327	327

Notes: Media coverage decomposed by outlet type. Each column re-estimates the benchmark specification with local coverage plus one external category: all non-local outlets, national media, foreign media, or other out-of-province domestic outlets. The negative career effect concentrates in domestic outlets outside the incumbent's jurisdiction but inside the domestic political audience: national and out-of-province domestic outlets are negative and significant; local and foreign outlets are null. What binds is the joint condition of political-audience reach and insulation from local authority. Standard errors clustered at prefecture; same controls as Table 2. $^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$.

5 Discussion

The empirical contribution is to identify which information channels enter the promotion technology of a decentralized authoritarian hierarchy. Three findings from the preceding analysis point in that direction. Local media carries no measurable discipline; non-local media does. The penalty on exposed incumbents runs through their probability of advancement, not through their probability of removal. And a descriptive mediation decomposition is directionally consistent with media coverage as the operative channel, though it is fragile enough under small unobserved confounding that the paper does not assign a specific share to the media pathway. Taken together, these results sketch a specific institutional logic of cadre management in China during the 2003–2012 decade studied here.

The logic is one of *outside scrutiny*. An incumbent party secretary exercises substantial—though not total—influence over the volume and tone of reporting within his own province. Central and commercial outlets based elsewhere are not subject to that influence; they operate under editorial logics that the local hierarchy cannot easily bend. For media coverage to function as an accountability signal from the center's point of view, then, it must travel through channels the local incumbent cannot manipulate. The commercialization and partial de-politicization of the Chinese news ecosystem in the 2000s did not produce media freedom in any normatively thick sense, but it did produce an information technology—outside-of-province outlets reporting on local events—that central authorities could use to discipline bureaucratic advancement without delegating formal sanction authority to the press. What I label the "outside-scrutiny" channel is not media freedom; it is the narrow slice of it that

lies beyond local political reach.

The advancement-margin finding sharpens the interpretation. If exposure triggered a punitive logic, one would expect the penalty to land on termination or demotion. It does not. The effect lands instead on the combination of retirement and promotion—the two modes through which a leader moves *forward* out of the current post—while leaving lateral reassignment and outright removal unaffected. In a tournament in which many candidates compete for a small number of higher-level positions, a weak negative signal need not remove anyone from office; it needs only to shift the ordering. That is precisely the pattern I observe, and it aligns with broader evidence on the Chinese promotion tournament (Jia, Kudamatsu and Seim 2015, Wang, Yao and Zhang 2022).

Two caveats warrant emphasis. First, the paper does not deliver a tight causal point estimate for the effect of non-local coverage on careers. The news-congestion IV is directionally consistent with the OLS but, under Anderson-Rubin inference, cannot reject zero. The RD at the ten-death threshold produces a clean first-stage on coverage but a noisy reduced form. The mediation decomposition is statistically marginal and sensitive to unobserved confounding. What the paper provides is a robust descriptive asymmetry—local silence, distant witness—combined with a differential first-stage that validates the mechanism's directional implications. The empirical claim is precisely this combination: that local and non-local coverage sit in qualitatively different positions in the accountability architecture, and that the central leadership uses only the latter to shape promotion outcomes.

Second, the mechanism is bounded in time. The account advanced here rests on the operational independence of non-local outlets from the local leaders they scrutinize; to the extent that subsequent changes in the Chinese media environment have compressed that independence (Qiaoan and Teets 2020, Waight et al. 2025, Wallace 2022), the accountability power of non-local media should weaken correspondingly. I flag this as a limitation of external validity rather than develop it further here, since the empirical window of the paper is 2003–2012 and the post-period dynamics warrant separate investigation.

A final puzzle the data do not resolve concerns behavioral feedback. Prefectures that received high non-local coverage in year t show no significant change in accident rates in year $t + 1$. The career consequences documented here do not translate, within the short horizon observable, into measurable adjustments in local safety provision. The accountability technology may therefore operate more as an instrument of cadre sorting—adjusting who advances within the hierarchy—than as an instrument of direct behavioral incentive. The distinction has welfare implications that this paper can only flag; resolving them awaits better instruments and richer data covering the years beyond our window.

6 Conclusion

The contribution of this paper is to identify which information channels enter the promotion technology of a decentralized authoritarian hierarchy. Media scrutiny is commonly understood as a symptom of democratic accountability; the evidence here suggests that, for Chinese prefecture leaders during 2003–2012, the disciplinary channel ran through a narrower institutional feature—the operational independence of non-local outlets from the very leaders they scrutinized. Local coverage had no measurable effect on turnover; coverage originating

outside the accident's province did. The penalty concentrated not on formal removal but on the probability of advancing forward through retirement or promotion. A news-congestion instrument specific to non-local reporting produced first-stage variation that local coverage did not share, corroborating the asymmetric mechanism. A mediation decomposition is directionally consistent with media coverage as the operative channel, but is sensitive to small unobserved confounding and is reported only as suggestive attribution.

Three limitations shape the interpretation. The identification strategy does not yield tight causal magnitudes; the paper's quantitative claims are descriptive plus mechanism-consistent rather than strictly causal. The analysis is bounded to 2003–2012, and the mechanism is institutionally contingent on the operational independence of non-local media from local leaders; external validity to periods or settings in which that independence is weaker should not be assumed. And the absence of detectable behavioral feedback in next-year accident rates suggests that the observed technology adjusts cadre sorting more than it changes on-the-ground incentives, a distinction with welfare implications that the present data cannot resolve.

Several extensions suggest themselves. Richer text-based measures of coverage—beyond simple article counts—would allow the mechanism to be tested at the level of framing and tone rather than volume. Mapping interactions between non-local reporting and internal disciplinary processes, such as inspection groups, audits, and activity by the Discipline and Inspection Commission, could adjudicate whether media visibility triggers, accompanies, or merely reflects central attention. Most consequentially, as data from more recent years becomes available, a direct test of how the mechanism responds to changes in the operational independence of the non-local media channel becomes feasible, providing an out-of-sample check on the institutional account advanced here.

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APPENDIX:
Outside the Magistrate's Shadow: Media Beyond Local Authority and Cadre Promotion in China

This appendix documents material that is too bulky or too specialized for the main text but that is essential for understanding, evaluating, and reproducing the paper's empirical claims. Section A.1 describes the variable-construction rules that translate raw cadre career destinations into the four-level turnover outcome used throughout the paper. Section A.2 presents the non-parametric visualization of the horse race between non-local and local coverage. Sections A.3 through A.5 report robustness to alternative estimators and alternative media-aggregation windows. Section A.6 reports the falsification test for endogenous leader appointment.

A.1 Political Turnover Coding Rules

The dependent variable throughout the paper is a four-level ordinal measure of political turnover for incumbent prefecture party secretaries. Constructing this variable requires a mapping from the raw career destinations observed in cadre biographies—several hundred distinct Chinese bureaucratic titles—to a small number of substantively meaningful categories. Table A.1 documents the complete mapping. It is reproduced in the appendix rather than summarized in the main text because the specific coding choices are consequential for the paper's advancement-margin interpretation and should be auditable.

The coding collapses destinations onto four codes: 3 for promotions into positions with greater executive authority; 2 for lateral transfers or staying in the incumbent position; 1 for retirements and politically weak "graceful exit" positions; and 0 for formal terminations. Two choices merit emphasis. First, appointments to the provincial People's Congress or to the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC), whether as chair, vice-chair, or secretary-general, are coded as Code 1 rather than Code 3. These are nominally senior positions but they carry loss of executive authority—the Chinese practice commonly described as "第二线" (*second line*)—and treating them as promotions would misclassify what is in practice a graceful exit. Second, transitions to another prefecture-level city in an equivalent role are coded as Code 2 (lateral) rather than Code 3 (promotion), because the administrative rank is unchanged. These conventions follow Li and Zhou (2005) and Chen and Xu (2017*b*) and are the foundation of the advancement-margin result in Table 3: it is the code-3-versus-code-1 partition, not a formal removal margin, that the non-local-media signal moves.

Table A.1: Political Turnover Coding Rules

Position in Chinese	Code	Position in English
A secretary is "promoted" if he/she attains one of the following positions upon the end of term:		
省委副书记	3	Deputy secretary of the provincial party committee
省委组织部长	3	Head of the provincial organization department
省纪检委书记	3	Secretary of the provincial discipline inspection commission
省委宣传部部长	3	Head of the provincial propaganda department
省委秘书长	3	Secretary-general of the provincial party committee
省政法委书记	3	Head of the provincial political and legal affairs commission
副省长	3	Vice provincial governor
省政府秘书长	3	Secretary-general of the provincial government
省发改委主任	3	Head of the provincial development and reform commission
省公安厅厅长	3	Head of the provincial public security department
省高级人民法院院长	3	Chief judge of the provincial high court
省高级人民检察院检察长	3	Head of the provincial procuratorate
省财政厅厅长	3	Head of the provincial finance department
省地税厅厅长	3	Head of the provincial local tax department
副省级城市市委书记	3	Party secretary of a sub-provincial city
副省级城市市长	3	Mayor of a sub-provincial city
A secretary is "transferred laterally" or "stayed in the same position" if he/she ends up with one of the following position upon the end of term		
地级市市委书记	2	Secretary of another prefecture-level city
省政府副秘书长	2	Deputy secretary-general of the provincial government
省委副秘书长	2	Deputy secretary-general of the provincial party committee
省委组织部副部长	2	Deputy head of the provincial organization department
省委宣传部副部长	2	Deputy head of the provincial propaganda department
省委政法委副书记	2	Deputy head of the provincial political and legal affairs commission
省政府省长助理	2	Assistant to the provincial governor
省政府巡视员	2	Provincial-level counselor or inspector
省发改委副书记	2	Deputy head of the provincial development and reform commission
省公安局副局长	2	Deputy head of the provincial public security department
省高级人民法院副院长	2	Vice chief judge of the provincial high court
省高级人民检察院副院长	2	Deputy head of the provincial procuratorate
省政府各厅厅长（如教育厅厅长）	2	Head of another provincial functional bureau (e.g. education)
A secretary is "retired" if he/she ends up with one of the following position upon the end of term		
现任职地级市市长	1	Mayor of the same prefecture-level city
其他地级市市长	1	Mayor of a different prefecture-level city
省人大主席，副主席	1	Chair or vice-chair of the provincial people's congress
省政协主席，副主席	1	Chair or vice-chair of the provincial CPPCC
省人大秘书长，副秘书长	1	Secretary-general or deputy secretary-general of the provincial people's congress
省政协秘书长，副秘书长	1	Secretary-general or deputy secretary-general of the provincial CPPCC
省政府各厅副厅长（如教育厅副厅长）	1	Deputy head of a provincial functional bureau
地级市人大常委会主任，副主任	1	Chair or vice-chair of the prefectural people's congress
地级市政协主席，副主席	1	Chair or vice-chair of the prefectural CPPCC
省总工会主席	1	Head of the provincial trade union federation
省妇联主席	1	Head of the provincial women's federation
地级市总工会主席	1	Head of the prefectural trade union federation
地级市妇联主席	1	Head of the prefectural women's federation
地级市政府各局局长（如教育局局长）	1	Head of a prefectural functional bureau
退休	1	Retirement
A secretary is "terminated" if he/she ends up with one of the following position upon the end of term		
自然死亡	0	Had their office terminated due to natural death
辞职	0	Had their office terminated due to resignation
涉嫌贪污渎职被调查	0	Had their office terminated due to corruption investigation

Notes: Coding rules mapping raw career destinations into the paper's four-level turnover outcome. Code 3 = promotion; Code 2 = lateral transfer or staying; Code 1 = retirement or a politically weak "graceful exit" position; Code 0 = termination. Chinese titles are retained alongside English translations so readers can verify each destination's exact bureaucratic rank. The coding treats appointments to the provincial people's congress or CPPCC as retirements rather than promotions because they imply loss of executive authority—the distinction that lets the main text locate the non-local-media penalty on the advancement margin rather than on outright dismissal.

A.2 Non-Parametric Visualization of the Horse Race

Section 4.1 uses a linear-probability horse race to separate the career impact of non-local coverage from that of local coverage. A reader might reasonably wonder whether the asymmetry documented there is driven by the functional form of the regression—whether it persists, for instance, once one relaxes linearity. Figure A.1 reports a non-parametric counterpart to the horse race, plotting LOWESS fits of turnover against each of the three identifying variables in the accident-year sample.

Panel 1 of the figure plots fatalities directly. Panels 2 and 3 plot turnover against the residual coverage measures obtained by regressing $\log(NewsNonLocal + 1)$ and $\log(NewsLocal + 1)$, respectively, on fatalities. This Frisch–Waugh–Lovell-style residualization isolates the component of each coverage variable that cannot be explained by accident severity, which is precisely the component the horse-race coefficients are recovering in Table 2. If the linear horse race were picking up a functional-form artifact, the non-parametric fit to the residualized variable should look qualitatively different from the regression line. It does not. In Panel 2, the LOWESS curve slopes downward across the full range of the non-local residual, closely tracing the negative linear coefficient from the main-text specification. In Panel 3, the corresponding curve for the local residual is essentially flat, exactly as the null local-coverage coefficient in the main text would predict. The visual evidence therefore reinforces the regression evidence without imposing a parametric form.

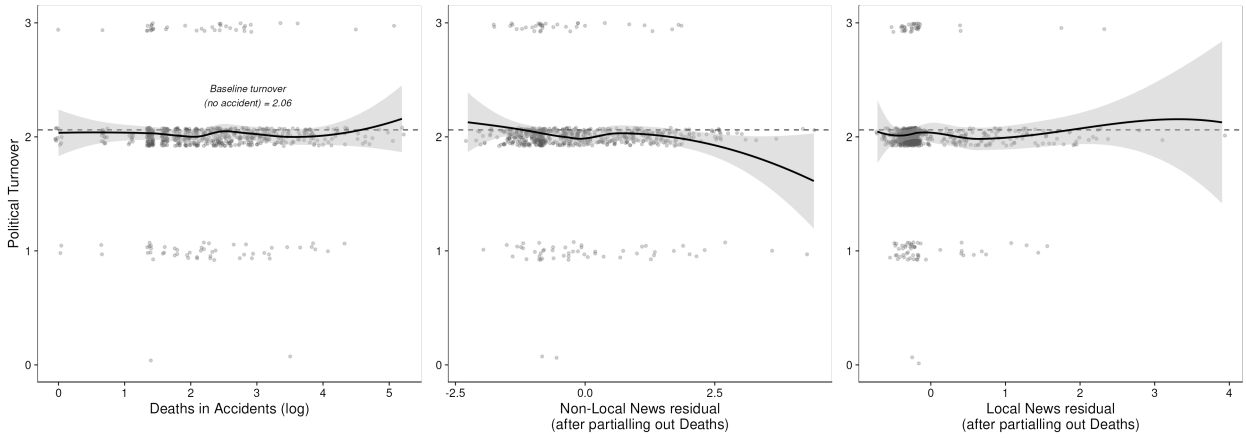

Figure A.1: Residual Scatter: Deaths, Non-Local News, and Local News versus Turnover

Notes: LOWESS fits (black line, shaded 95% confidence band) with jittered observations (grey points) for the accident-year sample. Panel 1: log(Deaths+1). Panel 2: residuals from regressing $\log(NewsNonLocal + 1)$ on log(Deaths+1)—coverage by outlets outside the incumbent's province, net of severity. Panel 3: residuals from regressing $\log(NewsLocal + 1)$ on log(Deaths+1)—coverage by outlets inside the incumbent's province, net of severity. The dashed horizontal line marks the average turnover among non-accident observations (2.06). The figure is the non-parametric visual counterpart of the horse race in Table 2: non-local coverage slopes downward even after severity is partialled out, while local coverage is flat.

A.3 Alternative Estimator: Ordered Logistic Regression

The benchmark specification in Equation 1 treats the four-level turnover outcome as approximately cardinal and estimates the model by ordinary least squares with two-way fixed effects. A standard concern with this choice is that forcing an ordinal variable onto a cardinal scale could, in principle, distort the estimated relationships: an outcome difference between codes 2 and 3 is assumed to have the same weight as a difference between codes 0 and 1, and that assumption is not guaranteed. Table A.2 re-estimates the same specification using ordered logistic regression via `MASS::polr`, which exploits only the ordinal ranking of the four turnover codes and makes no cardinalization assumption.

The results are qualitatively identical to the main-text specification. The interaction between the accident indicator and non-local coverage remains negative and highly significant across specifications, with proportional-odds coefficients between roughly -0.26 and -0.32. The corresponding local-coverage interaction is small, imprecise, and statistically indistinguishable from zero. Because the reported coefficients are log-odds under the proportional-odds model, their numerical magnitudes are not directly comparable to the linear-probability estimates in Table 2, but the sign and significance pattern reproduces in full. This rules out the most obvious estimator-related alternative explanation for the benchmark result.

Table A.2: The Benchmark Results (Ordered Logistic via MASS::polr)

	Dependent variable:					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Accident	-0.201^{***}	-0.470^{***}	-0.715^{***}	1.629^{***}	1.665^{***}	1.667^{***}
	(0.018)	(0.038)	(0.032)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.005)
Accident x Death (log)	-0.147^{***}	0.167^{***}	-0.086^{*}	-0.071	-0.113^{**}	-0.114^{**}
	(0.046)	(0.064)	(0.051)	(0.046)	(0.045)	(0.048)
Accident x Media Coverage (log)		-0.319^{***}	-0.298^{***}	-0.268^{***}	-0.255^{***}	-0.255^{***}
		(0.092)	(0.091)	(0.068)	(0.068)	(0.068)
Accident x Number of Accidents (log)			0.828^{***}	0.786^{***}	0.839^{***}	0.839^{***}
			(0.032)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.020)
Accident x Total Coverage (log)				-0.387^{***}	-0.390^{***}	-0.391^{***}
				(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.034)
Local Cadre					-0.252^{**}	-0.252^{**}
					(0.109)	(0.110)
Local Provincial PS					-0.464^{***}	-0.494^{***}
					(0.020)	(0.084)
Political Connection (Colleague)						-0.009
						(0.117)
Political Connection (Hometown)						0.040
						(0.092)
Observations	2,512	2,512	2,512	2,512	2,512	2,512

Notes: Main turnover model re-estimated under an ordered-logit specification (`MASS::polr`) rather than the baseline linear fixed-effects model, to verify the headline result is not an artifact of cardinalizing the four-level outcome. The accident-by-media interaction remains negative and statistically significant across specifications. Standard errors clustered at prefecture; prefecture and year fixed effects and baseline controls included. $^{*}p < 0.1$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{***}p < 0.01$.

A.4 Alternative Media Window: 365-Day Post-Accident Window

The baseline coverage variable counts all articles published about a given accident between the accident date and the end of the incumbent's tenure. This choice is natural given that the outcome variable is the incumbent's career trajectory over the same period, but it does allow articles published several years after an accident to contribute to a leader's exposure measure—which a skeptic could argue is "accumulated scrutiny" rather than "initial scrutiny." Table A.3 addresses this concern by restricting the news variable to articles published within 365 days of the accident.

Under this tighter window, the coefficient on the accident-by-non-local-coverage interaction remains negative and statistically significant in the richer specifications, and is of the same order of magnitude as the baseline. The accident-by-local-coverage interaction remains null. The result thus does not depend on the specific post-accident horizon over which coverage is aggregated; it is driven by proximate, within-year-of-the-accident attention rather than by long-tail reporting.

Table A.3: Robustness: Benchmark with t+365 days News Window

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Accident	−0.014	−0.045	−0.081	0.194	0.208	0.212
	(0.050)	(0.052)	(0.055)	(0.175)	(0.179)	(0.179)
Accident × Log(Death)	−0.023	0.016	−0.016	−0.015	−0.025	−0.010
	(0.020)	(0.026)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.032)	(0.032)
Accident × Log(Total News)		-0.040^{**}	-0.037^{**}	-0.034^{**}	-0.032^{*}	-0.032^{*}
		(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.018)
Accident × Log(# Accidents)			0.113^{*}	0.108	0.135^{**}	0.104
			(0.064)	(0.066)	(0.068)	(0.069)
Accident × Log(Prefecture Attention)				−0.045	-0.048^{*}	-0.049^{*}
				(0.027)	(0.028)	(0.028)
Local Cadre					−0.043	−0.036
					(0.027)	(0.028)
Local Provincial PS					-0.088^{***}	−0.075
					(0.031)	(0.049)
Political Connection (Colleague)						−0.006
						(0.030)
Political Connection (Hometown)						0.007
						(0.050)
R^2	0.154	0.156	0.157	0.159	0.162	0.165
Adj. R^2	0.043	0.045	0.046	0.047	0.049	0.049
Num. obs.	2989	2989	2989	2989	2956	2911
N Clusters	328	328	328	328	327	327

Notes: Robustness check redefining the news variable over a 365-day backward-looking window instead of the baseline window. The accident-by-media coefficient remains negative and significant in the richer specifications, indicating the result is not an artifact of the specific post-accident aggregation window. Standard errors clustered at prefecture; baseline controls and fixed effects as in Table 2. $^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$.

A.5 Alternative Media Window: Same Calendar Year

Table A.4 tightens the coverage window further, restricting the news variable to articles published in the same calendar year as the accident. This is the most conservative defensible window: it excludes coverage from the following calendar year entirely and therefore isolates contemporaneous media attention. The motivation is the same as in Section A.4 but stricter—a reviewer might plausibly believe that reporting in year $t + 1$ reflects rather than produces turnover changes, and one way to rule this out is to cut that year off from the measure.

The asymmetric pattern survives. Non-local coverage retains a significant negative interaction with the accident indicator in the fully controlled specification; local coverage remains null. Taken together with Section A.4, this brackets the baseline media-aggregation window from both sides and demonstrates that the horse-race result is stable across reasonable alternative operationalizations of "coverage following a scandal."

Table A.4: Robustness: Benchmark with Same-Year News Window

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Accident	−0.014	−0.048	−0.083	0.190	0.203	0.208
	(0.050)	(0.052)	(0.055)	(0.175)	(0.179)	(0.179)
Accident × Log(Death)	−0.023	0.019	−0.013	−0.011	−0.021	−0.007
	(0.020)	(0.026)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.032)	(0.032)
Accident × Log(Total News)		−0.043**	−0.041**	−0.038**	−0.035*	−0.035*
		(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Accident × Log(# Accidents)			0.111*	0.106	0.133**	0.102
			(0.064)	(0.065)	(0.067)	(0.069)
Accident × Log(Prefecture Attention)				−0.045	−0.048*	−0.049*
				(0.027)	(0.028)	(0.028)
Local Cadre					−0.043	−0.035
					(0.027)	(0.028)
Local Provincial PS					−0.089***	−0.074
					(0.031)	(0.049)
Political Connection (Colleague)						−0.006
						(0.030)
Political Connection (Hometown)						0.007
						(0.050)
R^2	0.154	0.157	0.158	0.159	0.162	0.165
Adj. R^2	0.043	0.046	0.046	0.047	0.050	0.050
Num. obs.	2989	2989	2989	2989	2956	2911
N Clusters	328	328	328	328	327	327

Notes: Robustness check restricting the media variable to articles published in the same calendar year as the accident—a more conservative window than the baseline. The accident-by-media coefficient remains negative and significant. Together with Table A.3, this brackets the baseline estimate and shows stability across reasonable alternative exposure definitions. Standard errors clustered at prefecture; baseline controls and fixed effects as in Table 2. $^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$.

A.6 Falsification: Endogenous Leader Appointment

Prefecture fixed effects absorb any time-invariant characteristic of a prefecture that might bias the accident-media-turnover relationship. A distinct concern, however, is *dynamic* selection. Suppose accident-prone jurisdictions systematically received better-connected—and therefore career-insulated—cadres after a period of bad safety record. In that case, the observed career penalty could reflect who was *assigned* to accident-prone prefectures rather than how accidents affect sitting incumbents, and prefecture fixed effects would not rule it out. Table A.5 directly tests this dynamic-selection alternative.

Each column of the table regresses one background characteristic of the newly appointed prefecture party secretary—workplace ties to the incumbent provincial leader, hometown ties, local origin, prior Communist Youth League experience, prior propaganda-system experience, and several others—on the prefecture's accident history and media coverage observed *before* the secretary's appointment. If accident-prone or high-scrutiny prefectures were systematically assigned certain kinds of cadres, these prior variables should predict incumbent characteristics. They do not: seventeen of the eighteen reported coefficients are statistically indistinguishable from zero, and the one marginally significant exception does not survive a Bonferroni correction for multiple testing. The falsification test therefore gives no evidence for the dynamic-selection mechanism, supporting the interpretation of the main-text results as within-prefecture responses of sitting incumbents rather than as an artifact of who gets sent where.

Table A.5: Endogeneity of Leader Appointment: Falsification Test

	Workplace Connection	Hometown Connection	Local Origin	Local Prov PS	CYL Experience	Propaganda Experience
Log(Prior Deaths+1)	−0.0413	−0.0377	+0.0723	−0.0372**	+0.0493	+0.0478
	(0.0488)	(0.0440)	(0.0541)	(0.0170)	(0.0468)	(0.0403)
Log(Prior Cases+1)	+0.0696	+0.0231	−0.1699	+0.0038	−0.0996	−0.0528
	(0.1014)	(0.0835)	(0.1074)	(0.0334)	(0.0964)	(0.0781)
Log(Prior Coverage+1)	−0.0009	+0.0109	+0.0213	+0.0201	−0.0028	−0.0087
	(0.0240)	(0.0201)	(0.0305)	(0.0160)	(0.0287)	(0.0258)
Observations	756	767	767	776	749	749
R^2	0.014	0.010	0.014	0.023	0.041	0.022

Notes: Falsification test for endogenous leader assignment. Each column regresses one leader background characteristic (workplace ties, hometown ties, local origin, CYL experience, propaganda experience, etc.) on prior-prefecture accident severity, frequency, and media coverage observed before appointment. If accident-prone or high-scrutiny jurisdictions received systematically different leader types, these regressors should predict leader characteristics. They generally do not: 17 of 18 coefficients are null, and the single marginal exception fails a Bonferroni correction. Standard errors clustered at prefecture; age, education, and year fixed effects included. $^{*}p < 0.10$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{***}p < 0.01$.